In that context, especially since 2014, India has taken active steps to empower the Global South. Lines of credit and grant assistance have been vehicles to execute socio-economic projects of varying levels of magnitude. These range from power plants, dams and transmission lines to public buildings, housing projects, rail and road links, agricultural processing and IT centres. While many have been undertaken at a national scale, hundreds of smaller initiatives at the community level have had an equally effective impact. The creation of assets and facilities has also been supported by extensive training and imparting of best practices.

What differentiates India's endeavours is a conscious policy of responding to the priorities and needs of the partner country involved. Prime Minister Modi's articulation of the Kampala Principles of development partnership in 2018 really set our country apart. Unlike cases where such initiatives have been driven by extractive objectives, India's efforts are aimed more at ensuring self-reliance; and the partners appreciate it. India matters to the Global South because there are few others who have taken such an approach.

India also matters by displaying its own distinctive characteristics. As its capabilities and influence grow, its representatives are often asked in other parts of the world why it would not emulate the behavioural pattern of those who have risen before it. Obviously, such queries emanate from people who are unfamiliar with India's DNA.

It is essential, therefore, that India differentiates itself by highlighting its own national qualities, beliefs and traditions. The most basic of them is its inherent pluralism, one that allows its unity to be expressed in diversity. Flowing from that is its democratic ethos. This is not just a trait to be practised at home but equally one visible in consultations abroad. Adherence to laws and rules is another important point to emphasize with an international audience. As a corollary, we are not a polity given to pursuing coercive approaches or seeking one-sided gains. Indeed, the sum total of India's engagement with the global community over multiple decades, if not more, is of treating the world as a family. Nowhere is that more visible than in periods of stress, such as the tribulations of recent years.

NEW INDIA AND THE GLOBAL AGENDA